A course in language creation

Conlangs University

Introduction to Conlanging

What it is, who does it, and why do it

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This document is intended as a general introduction to the multiple facets of conlanging, and may (will) repeat some information from section to section.

All of this document and the following chapters will assume that the reader is fully proficient in English.

What's (in) a conlang?

> What the fuck?
> — A user from r/worldbuilding, after straying away from the safe path of just using weird English. Probably.

First off, what is a conlang?
Short for **con**structed **lang**uage, a conlang is a language that was consciously created by someone, rather than evolving naturally over time like "natlangs" (**nat**ural **lang**uages). Other names for conlangs include model languages, artificial languages, imaginary languages, invented languages, or planned languages. Some refer to "conlanging" (the process of creating a language) as "glossopoeia", from Ancient Greek γλῶσσᾰ (glôssa) meaning "tongue/language" and ποιέω (poiéō) meaning "to make". Though this term predates "conlang" and was used by J. R. R. Tolkien, it is considerably less popular, perhaps because it's not quite as transparent to your average English speaker. This document will use "conlang" throughout, as it's by far the most common term and the terms derived from it are much simpler: conlanger (one who makes a conlang), conlanging (the process of making a conlang).

A conlang is not simply a code, a cypher, or a twist on your native language (or any other natural language). It is designing a new means of communication, a new language entirely. A conlanger decides as they design the language what they want it to be used for. They could intend for it to be spoken for the entire world, or they could design it for themselves alone. It doesn't even need to be spoken at all. The choice is up to the conlanger.

A definition of *conlanging*

It's very hard to give a single definition to "conlanging" or "conlang", because none is really perfect, and which languages count as constructed is subject to interpretation. For instance, linguists reconstruct ancient languages like Proto-Indo-European by studying the languages that descended from it and making educated guesses based on their common features. Some might consider this a conlang, others might not. In a similar way, Modern Hebrew is the result of a conscious revival effort, as Hebrew hadn't been spoken natively for hundreds of years before its revival in the 19th and 20th centuries. Does this make it a conlang? Some think so, others don't.

I, as well as this series of articles, do not consider reconstructions or modern Hebrew to be conlangs.

For the purposes of this series, we will work with the following definition of *conlanging*: "A conscious effort to create a language not naturally evolved through speech communities".

Why bother at all?

Then, you may be asking yourself:

> Why construct a whole language? Why not just make up a few words and use those, thrown together in a sorta-plausible manner and use the result? No one will care about how realistic the language *is*, only about how realistic it *feels* after all!

Why not? Many find the process of creating a language fun and enjoy crafting a language that fits their tastes and allows them to explore linguistic concepts. Creating a language can be part of fleshing out a fictional world through one of the most challenging worldbuilding tasks, or it can be about answering a "what if...?" and mixing linguistics with artistic expression.

Others are driven by the desire to make communication between humans more open or efficient, either on a regional level or as a whole. After all, any natural *lingua franca* will inevitably give its native speakers an unfair advantage on the world stage, and an easy-to-learn conlang that is the second language of all could even the playing field. Or perhaps a given conlanger is frustrated with the many ambiguities of natural language, and seeks to design a language that lacks them.

There are probably nearly as many motives for conlanging as there are conlangers. While conlangs can be categorized based on their creators' design goals (which we'll get into later), in the end, most conlangers conlang for one ultimate reason -- because they enjoy it.

> Why learn a conlang?

First, it should be noted that those who create conlangs don't necessarily want to learn to speak conlangs or get others to learn the conlangs they've created. Many conlangers aren't particularly interested in either and find the fun in the process of creating a language rather than in using the language for any practical purpose.

However, from the perspective of those interested in learning, conlangs are their own languages like any others. Therefore, they are subject to the same process of "should I learn it?" as any other language. Those who wish to learn conlangs do so for the same reasons people wish to learn natlangs -- to interact with and become part of a community of speakers. Some learn because they're super interested in something related to the conlang, others learn just for bragging rights. Of course, one could argue that learning a conlang is impractical, since there are few, if any, speakers of a given conlang, but if we only learned languages based on their usefulness we'd all be speaking the same 10 languages anyway.

In the end, those who are interested in learning conlangs should go ahead and give it a try, but no one should be pressured into learning one.

> Why bother learning or constructing a fictional language when you could work on saving Welsh or other endangered languages?

There may not be a good answer to this. There is no big argument that makes language creation or learning a conlang objectively more attractive than documenting or learning endangered languages. However, it should be noted that documenting endangered languages has real-world implications and carries a lot of responsibilities you will need proper training to handle. Even just learning endangered languages requires sensitivity to the sociocultural issues of that language's existing speakers -- and that's if they happen to be somewhere with easy access to an endangered language's speaker community and resources for learners, which is not the case for many people.

This question (and, really, it's more of an accusation) is much like asking why someone would bother whistling when they could be building shelter for the homeless. Just because someone could be doing something that is better for society doesn't mean they're obligated to do so at the expense of ever enjoying themselves. Protesting hobbies because those who partake in them "could be doing something more productive" doesn't accomplish much but try and guilt people out of doing something harmless and fun, and it tends to overlook a lot of obvious differences between the time, energy, and resource requirements of the hobby when compared with the more "productive" task.

In the end, it's up to what people want. If you don't see a point in conlanging, do not conlang. If you want to learn an endangered language, learn it.

And anyway, why not do both? Field linguists can be conlangers too!

> Why do *you* create languages?

The answer you'll get to this question will vary a lot by conlanger, but we authors will try to give a taste of our individual motivations for conlanging.

Slorany:

I began conlanging for a conworld I was using for a D&D campaign. Displeased with the way spells were handled in the game, with a set list of pre-defined effects, I chose to craft my own magic system, based on "runes", essentially keywords that gave the Magic an order and could be combined for more complex and powerful spells. Pretty early on, I thought "hey wouldn't it be cool if the words were not in my magic language and the players actually had to learn them? I could make a magic language! Such RP opportunities!". How naïve of me, they never learned the language. But that was my jumping in the rabbit hole of conlanging.
Since then, most of my conlangs are set in this world, which I am still building to this day, all these years later.

Sparksbet:

The idea of building my own language appealled to me from quite a young age -- as a child I'd make up my own "languages" for the fairy stories I'd imagine in my free time. Though these were usually just codes and word games, they were an omen of things to come. In high school, a YouTuber I followed at the time made a video about Esperanto, and I learned it on a whim over my summer vacation. I learned that I enjoyed the process of translating things into Esperanto even though realistically no one would read it, and I started learning more and more about linguistics. As I went on to do my bachelor's degree in linguistics, I went back to inventing languages for fantasy stories I planned to someday write -- this time with more linguistic knowledge, quasi-naturalism, and some artistic flair. The fantasy stories themselves haven't materialized yet, but the act of conlanging is fun enough on its own even if they never do.

Adarain:

I discovered conlanging more or less serendipitously and simply found it intriguing. So I gave it a shot without much thought behind it, and it turned out to be extremely interesting! I discovered a whole science that I had never really considered or thought could be interesting at all (linguistics), and through conlanging I had a medium which allowed me to learn more about it. See, I'm someone who loves to learn but always needs that extra push to actually do research. But conlanging was exactly that push. By trying to figure out how to express myself in my languages, I was pushed to learn more about how languages work themselves. So, that's my answer, I guess. Because I love to learn, and conlanging let me do that.

Famous conlangs

Here we list a few well-known works from language creators. You've seen or heard some of them, and others might be unknown to you but they have their importance to the discipline.

Abbess Hildegard of Bingen, creator of Lingua Ignota, seen as one of the very first conlangers.

Ludwig Lazarus Zamenhoff, creator of Esperanto, probably the most successful auxlang today.

David J. Peterson, creator of The 100's Trigedasleng, Game of Thrones' Dothraki and (High and Low) Valyrian, Bright's Övüsi and Bodzvokhan or Marvel's Doctor Strange's Nelvayu.

Christine Schreyer, creator of Man of Steel's Kryptonian.

Paul Frommer, creator of James Cameron's Avatar's Na'vi.

Mark Okrand, creator of Star Trek's Klingon and the Atlantean language used by Disney.

Nick Farmer, creator of the The Expanse's Belter Creole.

Ithkuil, an experiment in crafting a language with minimal ambiguity. It has some prog-rock songs written in it, for example this one, sung by David J. Peterson. I encourage you to look at the rest of John Quijada's YouTube channel for more!

Anthony Burgess, creator of Nadsat, a register of English used in his novel A Clockwork Orange, and Ulam, a prehistoric language constructed for The Quest for Fire.

Hergé, Belgian cartoonist known for the Adventures of Tintin, for which he created Syldavian (which is unfortunately not well-documented, as Hergé never wrote a reference).

Lingua Franca Nova (or LFN, or Elefen), an auxiliary language focused on the romance languages with a voluntarily reduced grammar, created by Cornelis George Boeree.

Lojban, developed by the Logical Language Group based on the older Loglan, a loglang designed by James Cooke Brown in the 1950s.

Quenya and Sindarin, both created by J. R. R. Tolkien.

Toki Pona, created by Sonja Lang, a minimal language with a few thousand speakers, mostly active online.

Volapük, created at the end of the 19th century as an IAL by a German catholic priest, Martin Schleyer.

The Voynich Manuscript may be an example of an entirely unknown language, though this is not a certainty.

Kinds of conlangs

There are many types of conlangs. Perhaps unsurprisingly for a group of people whose hobby involves making up words, conlangers love to label different types of conlangs based on a variety of features, including:

- whether the language is derived from any existing languages
- how the language is expressed
- the design goals of the language's creator
- whether the language is intended to imitate natural language or not

A conlang can bear more than just one label, and the categories we describe here are not exhaustive. We only aim to represent a broad majority of constructed languages.

Inspiration

Conlangs can be divided into two categories based on whether they take inspiration from existing languages or not -- any given conlang can be `a priori` or `a posteriori`. Meaning "from the former" and "from the latter" in Latin, these labels are taken from philosophical terminology.

An *a priori* conlang is one that is not derived from any existing language, while an *a posteriori* conlang is one that is has major parts directly derived from at least one real world language, extinct or extant. This ends up being more of a spectrum than a binary categorization -- few conlangs are so disconnected from real-world languages that they can't be said to take any influence from them, so the line between *a priori* and *a posteriori* is blurred at best.

A posteriori conlangs

While *a priori* conlangs can have almost any design philosophy imaginable, *a posteriori* conlangs tend to cluster into a few distinct categories with their own tendencies and characteristics. These categories can depend on what time period the language is supposedly from, as well as on other features of the language's fictional origin.

Futuristic

Works of science-fiction can play with the evolution of language through time, and sometimes do so under specific conditions. This is the case, for instance, with Trigedasleng, the language devised by David J. Peterson for the TV Series The 100. It is an evolution of a variety of American English many years in the future. Another proposed evolution of American English can be found in Futurese, the work of Justin B. Rye.

Such conlangs make use of what is called historical (or *diachronic*, "that happens over time") linguistics, applied over an arbitrary duration.

Alternative

Rather than projecting language out into the future, these languages tend to stay rooted in the past or present -- but with something new to offer that makes the language differ from any existing natlang.

Languages set in an alternative version of our world are generally called *altlangs*. The most well-known example is probably Brithenig, created by Andrew Smith, which is "a Romance language that might have evolved if Latin speakers had been a sufficient number to displace Old Celtic as the spoken language of the people in Great Britain".

A posteriori conlangs derived from particular well-known language families are often given their own names: the most common are romlangs (derived from **rom**ance **lang**uages), germlangs (derived from **germ**anic **lang**uages), and PIE-langs (derived from Proto-Indo-European). One example of a relatively recent, well-researched PIE-lang is /u/iasper and /u/darkgamma's Carisitt.

Some languages in this category do not involve worldbuilding at all, instead focusing on the language as a thought-experiment, without an attempt to give it a cultural background. This is the case for Latino sine flexione, a hypothetical evolution of Latin intended to be a simpler version without inflections intended for use as an international auxiliary language.

A few languages have been constructed with the intent to "explain" features in other languages. Those are set in our world, and are said to have had an influence on other languages. They are often called *lostlangs*, as the worldbuilding around them generally contains something to the effect of "everything about this language has been lost to history". The League of Lost Languages aims to provide a set of guidelines for such conlangs.

Pidgins & Creoles

Pidgins and creoles are types of languages that arise from two or more languages blending together. In real life, this is usually the result of necessity, be it through trade or, for most cases, colonialists imposing slavery upon people who did not speak the same language. They occurred when and where people needed to communicate between themselves and/or with outsiders.

Pidgins are means of communication that develop between individuals that do not share a language. They are grammatically very simple, out of necessity, and generally consist only of a core vocabulary, often focused on a few semantic fields. Their lexicon may borrow from all of the speakers' original languages, as well as onomatopoeia, though they tend to develop with one language contributing most of the lexicon. Creoles, on the other hand, are fully fledged languages able to express any thought just as any other natural language would. When speakers of a pidgin have children who are raised speaking the pidgin, those children naturally flesh out the grammar and vocabulary of the pidgin into a proper creole and serve as that creole's first native speakers.

A futuristic or alternative language can also be a pidgin or creole. One such example is Nick Farmer's Lang Belta, or Belter Creole, a futuristic language used in the TV show *The Expanse*.

Working Backwards: Reconstructions

A reconstruction can be considered to be an *a posteriori* process, even though it is working backwards in comparison to all other aforementioned methods.
A reconstructed language is supposed to be an ancestor, generally one that is not (fully) documented or recorded, to several other languages. Those reconstructions are not to be confused with the language *as it existed*, as they are only the product of educated guesses obtained through the use of the comparative method.

Official reconstructions are not generally considered to be conlangs because of their scientific nature, as opposed to a conlang's generally more artistic or experimental purpose.

Means of expression

How is the language used to carry information from one user to another?

While most languages are *spoken languages*, languages can be expressed in a multitude of other ways, each with its own interesting features and challenges.

Written languages

Even though they are not often separated, it is important to first distinguish *writing systems* from *written languages*.

- Writing systems, or orthographies, are ways to transcribe a language by means of a writing system. Said language is usually also spoken (though it may be expressed through another means instead).
- Written languages are ways of directly expressing thought in writing, without relying on an existing language other than themselves. They can sometimes also be referred to as written-*only* languages, if they are not used in any way other than writing.

This distinction is uncommon because *no natural language is exclusively written*. Writing systems for spoken languages will be covered later in the series of posts.

Some examples of written languages include:

- Sai and Alex Fink's UNLWS
- /u/digigon's Emojilang

Signed languages

Signed languages encode information in gestures, meaning the "listener" (the person receiving the information) has to watch at the "speaker" (or, more accurately, signer).

While many people may have learned to sign the letters of the Latin alphabet in their local sign language, modern sign languages are not just word-for-word signed versions of spoken languages. Sign languages have their own grammars that often differ significantly from those of the spoken languages around them. They can influence other sign languages independently from the spoken languages around them as well: for instance, ASL (American Sign Language) (used in the US and anglophone Canada) is derived from LSF (French Sign Language, Langue des Signes Française), rather than being related to BANZSL (British, Australian and New Zealand Sign Language).

Finding a good way to encode a signed language in writing is a challenge we haven't quite solved yet, but some have attempted to make systems for that. Here are a few examples:

- SLIPA
- SignWriting
- Stokoe notation

Some constructed languages have been derived, to an extent, from signed languages. This is the case of Steven Travis' Tapissary, which has a very interesting writing system that is based on the movements of ASL.

As for fully signed conlangs, we can not go without mentioning the rikchik language by Denis M. Moskowitz, the language of the rikchiks, 49-tentacled aliens who use 7 of those appendages to express themselves. This language is not intended to be spoken by humans, and as such a human is not expected to be able to ever reach any sort of fluency in it -- indeed we seem to lack a few of the requisite limbs.

Whistled languages

Whistled languages are quite rare, but whistled components in languages (slightly) less so, such as in Jalapa Mazatec or Pirahã. In the real world, whistling has mainly been used as a way to encrypt an existing language.

Due to their rarity, information on whistled languages is quite hard to find, but notable examples include Silbo Gomero in Spain, which is probably the most documented, the shepherds' whistled language in Aas, France, the Bird Language in Kuskoy, Turkey.

Drummed languages

In a manner comparable to the whistled languages mentioned above, some languages have a drummed register. Notable examples include the Bora language from Peruvian Amazonia or Congo's Kele language, whose drum register is now considered extinct.

Tactile languages

These languages are expressed by touch. In most cases, they could be considered either forms of written language, such as Braille, or of signed language suited to deaf-blind people, carried directly by contact from speaker to listener.

However, there can be more creative routes for tactile conlangs. The gripping language, developed by Alex Fink and Sai, is an example of a conlang fully based on touch.

Musical languages

Musical languages are languages based on musical notes, where the exact pitch of a note is generally important to the meaning of a word.

The most notable example is Solresol, invented by François Sudre in the first half of the 19th century. It now has a small fairly active community around it, which strangely (for a language created in France) seems to be comprised mostly of English speakers.
Solresol is also interesting in that it can be expressed through a variety of means, including colours, numerals, or any set of 7 distinct items. It also has its own stenographs.

Other examples include jackson Moore's Moss, a musical pidgin, and Bruce Koestner's Eaiea.

Note: A tonal language *is not* a musical language.

Limitations

Conlanging is in no way limited to the means described here. It is also not limited to humanoids (as exemplified by the Rikchik language mentioned above). Nothing is too ridiculous for a conlang. There are no limits other than those you give yourself. Be free.

Design Goals

As we described above, there are many different reasons for creating a language. A few of those reasons are so common that conlangers have invented words for the type of conlang that is designed with those reasons in mind -- we'll go into the most common types in this section.

Note that a single conlang can belong to more than one category at a time. They are in no way binding, nor are they exhaustive.

Artistic languages

Artistic languages, or artlangs, are those created for artistic purposes. This can be to supplement a fictional work, as part of a thought experiment, or just for fun.

Fictional languages are the most common type of artlangs. They are found in books (George Orwell's Newspeak, in *1984*), TV shows (David J. Peterson's Dothraki, in *Game of Thrones*), games (the Wenja and Izila languages in *Far Cry Primal*) or movies (Paul Frommer's Na'vi language from *Avatar* and Marc Okrand's Klingon language from the *Star Trek* films).

Auxiliary languages

Auxiliary languages, or auxlangs, are languages designed to facilitate communication between groups of real people, generally internationally (in which case it can be called an IAL, or International Auxiliary Language). As this is one of the oldest and most popular type of conlang, there are many of them. The aforementioned Latino sine flexione was designed to be an auxiliary language, but without a doubt the most famous and most successful example is Esperanto, which was designed in the late 1800s and has hundreds of thousands (perhaps even millions) of speakers, even including a few native speakers.

While auxiliary languages are often described as languages for the world, they don't necessarily need to be designed for literally everyone. Some auxlangs, sometimes called zonal conlangs, are intended only to serve as auxiliary languages between speakers of closely related languages. An example of a zonal auxlang is Interslavic, which was designed to facilitate communication among speakers of Slavic languages. Since more ambitious auxlangs often struggle to avoid appearing too obviously biased towards certain language families, zonal auxlangs tend to avoid a lot of the most common criticisms of auxlangs in general.

Engineered languages

Engineered languages, or eng(e)langs, are those created as an experiment, generally to explore logical or philosophical problems.

Philosophical engineered languages are designed to reflect or explore certain philosophical theories or beliefs. For example, Suzette Haden Elgin's Láaden was constructed to test the Sapir-Whorf Hypothesis and determine how a language designed to express the thoughts and views of women would affect culture. The most popular philosophical language nowadays is probably Sonja Lang's Toki Pona, a minimal language focused on simple and universal concepts.

Engineered languages designed based on the principles of formal logic are known as **log**ical **lang**uages, or loglangs. They are often intended to avoid or eliminate the syntactic ambiguity present in natural languages. Lojban is the most well-known example of a logical engineered language.

Secret languages

Secret languages can be any other type of conlang, and are only limited in that they are not intended to be taught or learned outside of perhaps a very small circle of people the creator knows. They are generally for obscuring one's note-taking and/or communicating in secret. They can range from a code with tweaks to the grammar (thus aren't fully new languages) to fully-fledged conlangs.

Personal languages are secret languages intended to only have one user: their author.

Naturalism

A language being `naturalistic` means it is plausible for it to be spoken by humans, based on our knowledge of the extant human languages.

How naturalistic a language is falls on a spectrum and can only be compared to an average of what languages do: the less cross-linguistically frequent a feature is, the less naturalistic it is deemed to be. As such, adding rare features to a conlang will make it seem less plausible (for human speakers) and more "alien". This can lead to a "kitchen sink language" (see below).

A language meant to be spoken by humans will generally be expected to be rather naturalistic and conform to what we know of human languages. At the other end of the spectrum, a language spoken by beings unrelated to humans will be expected to not follow the patterns of human languages. However, as with all things, there are exceptions.

Some might deliberately choose to design their language to include unnaturalistic features for purposes of experimentation, for aesthetic concerns, because of another specific design goal. This is particularly common among auxlangs and engelangs. However, unless a conlanger specifies that they're choosing to eschew naturalism for a specific reason, other conlangers will tend to assume that they are trying and failing to achieve naturalism.

It is typically assumed that any conlang presented without further information is an artistic language intended to be spoken by humans and thus to be naturalistic, and feedback from online conlanging communities tends to be given with this assumption in mind.

Other terms you might see

Relex

The term "relex", short for relexification, designates a language that is too close to a real-world language, generally the native language of the author. Also referred to as "involuntary cipher", it is most often used negatively. Many conlangers do not consider relexes to be conlangs, or languages of their own, and consider them more similar to codes: existing languages with the words changed.

Kitchen sink

Also a pejorative term, it is a way to refer to a language that has had seemingly random features thrown into it by its creator, without much consideration for the cohesiveness of the whole language. A kitchen sink language could be one with dozens of consonants that seem to have been chosen at random, or one with seemingly every redundant grammatical distinction known to man. Essentially, it's any language with too much stuff that doesn't fit together well.

SAE

SAE, or Standard Average European, is a term used for languages that resemble the major Western European languages, by purpose or by accident. This refers in particular to a certain set of grammatical features which are uncommon cross-linguistically but common among Western European languages. Jörg Rhiemeier offers a good introductory writeup on this.

Before we dive further...

If this short introduction managed to hook you in, you're probably (hopefully) wondering how you can get into the hobby. It may seem like a daunting task requiring a lot of work — and it is! — but that's the case with all forms of art.

Essentials

Getting familiar with a few languages, on a very basic level, would be great. I have a few suggestions, but feel free to go with your own:

- English, the language I assume most readers are native speakers of
- Mandarin Chinese, the language with the most native speakers in the world
- German, a language that is rather closely related to English, though it is considered to be a bit of challenge to learn by many because of its genders, cases and conjugations
- Zulu, an african language with 16 noun classes (genders)
- Nahuatl, a language that is peculiar in that it is *polysynthetic* (to make it short: a single Nahuan word can express a full sentence worth of English)
- Arabic, a Semitic language that makes use of consonantal roots
- Japanese
- Latin, a dead language with a lot of very well-known modern-day descendants

All (most) of the language-specific articles listed have a more specific "${language} grammar" page on Wikipedia. Feel free to also check that out.

As this guide goes on, you will need basic knowledge of the International Phonetic Alphabet. To help with this, there exist simple interactive IPA charts in slightly different colours.

If you wish to have a few basic resources handy before the first chapter, here are a few links that you can read independently to (very broadly) see some of the broad concepts this guide will cover:

- Language
- Typology
- Grammar
- Phonology
- Morphology
- Syntax
- Semantics

SIL International has a neat litle glossary of linguistics terms, as well as a reference for French and English linguistic terms.

The website Omniglot is an online encyclopedia, often referenced its quick overviews of writing systems.

The most recommended *conlanging* resources are:

- Mark Rosenfelder Language Construction Kit
  - which also exists as a book
  - and has a sequel
- David J. Peterson's The Art of Language Invention
  - which has an associated YouTube channel to further explain some topics

Communities

Conlangers gather in a few places, mostly online.

- The Language Creation Society
  - They hold bi-annual Language Creation Conferences
- The conlangs subreddit
  - And its Discord Server
- The conlangs StackExchange
- Conlangs, another Discord server
- A Facebook group
- Another Facebook group, this time also covering general linguistics
- A hispanophone facebook group
- A French forum

Note that you might not be able to understand *everything* in an article. That's perfectly fine and normal, linguistics is its own science and learning about it is a time-consuming endeavour.